ELECTRIC MOTION

AUTO INDUSTRY HONCHOS ON ELECTRIC VEHICLE ACCEPTANCE, UNLOCKING NEW CUSTOMER SEGMENTS, GOVERNMENT POLICIES TO PUSH EVs AND HOW INDIA CAN ACCELERATE THE TRANSITION TO CLEAN ENERGY VEHICLES



BALBIR SINGH DHILLON
Head, Audi India

VIKRAM PAWAH
President, BMW Group India

Q. HAS CUSTOMER ACCEPTANCE OF EVs IMPROVED?

● BALBIR SINGH DHILLON
At Audi India, we have seen continued demand for the e-tron range. We believe that electric car acceptance in the country is happening much faster than anticipated. With the recent launch of the Audi Q8 e-tron and the Audi Q8 Sportback e-tron, we are taking the next step in our electrification journey. We have six electric cars in our portfolio, the widest EV offering in the industry.

● VIKRAM PAWAH
BMW Group India remains dominant in the electric luxury segment thanks to its most diverse electric portfolio—BMW i7, BMW iX, BMW i4 and MINI SE. Till date, we have sold close to 1,000 battery electric vehicles (BEV), delivering 11 times more BEVs during H1 2023 than in H1 2022. The BMW iX is the best-selling BEV in the Indian luxury car segment. At present, it is the urban consumers that are driving a majority of the demand but prospects from emerging markets are firming up quickly in the medium to long term. We also have the best fast-charging infrastructure at the BMW Group Dealer Network in 35 cities, and it plays a vital role. We have opened it to customers of other electric car brands to promote e-mobility and address any range anxiety issues.

● TARUN GARG
Hyundai introduced India's first electric SUV, the KONA EV, in 2019 and subsequently launched IONIQ 5 this year. The response to both has been fantastic. We have adopted a top-down approach and introduced these two flagship products that have truly revolutionised the perception of EVs in India. Currently, HMI has a strong network of 119 EV dealerships in 54 cities.

● SANTOSH IYER
Mercedes-Benz pioneered luxury BEVs in India with the EQC, which laid the foundation for BEV adoption. Top-end luxury products, complementary wall-box chargers, charging facilities at home, office and dealerships, long-range batteries with industry best warranty, all these factors have contributed to a faster adoption of BEVs for our customers. Mercedes-Benz India currently has two BEVs in the portfolio—the EQB and the EQS.

● SHAILESH CHANDRA
With EVs available in the market at a price point of Rs 8 lakh on, people don't see it as an expensive proposition anymore. The running-cost benefit of EVs is gradually dawning on customers. They are no longer sceptical about durability too, thanks to the eight-year warranty on the powertrain. The EV industry has grown from 100 a month to nearly 10,000 a month. They have also unlocked new customer segments; 25 per cent of Tiago.ev customers are women, which is twice the industry average.